

Worth Fitting in this Groove



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The power of today's IT world can drastically work against you. The more powerful it gets, the more you are at risk in your personal world. The more you use it, the more you expose yourself and leave a trail for others to ambush you.

You need a way to plan your activities, share those photos of your last holiday with close friends, swap music, voice chat with friends, write papers together, do course work and even publish your own Web site and special interest forums. But doesn't that seem an expensive proposition in terms of time and money, neither of which you or me have an excess of? How many different programs will you buy, install and learn? And how will you keep all this information private and secure? Forget viruses, where do you keep snapshots of your previous girlfriend, so that your current one doesn't find them?

Check out Groove, the collaboration platform. I'll use that techie term, because this is not just a single application such as e-mail, ICQ or an instant messenger. This one tool does it all—it gives you the means to hide and share your files, in real time, with only the ones you choose to. Safe in a Groove workspace, you can say goodbye to viruses and spam, and all the risks of the open Web. You can even have your own private peer-to-peer network, which is not only powerful and easy to use, but impregnable as well.

This is one technology that you don't even have to set up as it does the technical work for you, as they all should ideally. In fact, there are no setup options. Just install and run—all settings are done automatically and internally to best suit your system.

One of the greatest advantages of Groove is its persistence. Everything you input, except for voice, is saved for later. Nothing gets lost, even if you format your machine. A copy of every file will exist with your peers, and they can restore it to you painlessly. In three years, I have never lost a single thing that I stored in Groove.

Groove comes with a full set of tools that you will typically need, and most of which are used by you in their pen and paper form. You can write together using the built-in Notes Editor, plan events using joint calendars, manage or even create images and video, sketch and paint together, track projects and events and even play games online, in privacy.

For some serious fun, you can create your own blogs, Web sites and forums that will air your thoughts and those of your peer group to the world. It's like having your own publishing house. Fight for world peace, or just the garbage collection in your neighbourhood—Groove tools and built-in Web services will do all the interaction and connectivity for you, with no technical demands. This is one powerful, mother of all software tools, and even old hacks like us find it exhilarating to discover new ways to use it every day. As technology writer Jon Udell said in a recent article, "Groove is at a place today, where MS and Sun, etc, would be happy to be by the year 2006..."

At the heart of Groove is the very human belief that people need to communicate and share for a better personal experience. Groove works by adding value to your network and trust based networks grow naturally.

Groove starts off for free, and remains so if it is for personal use. You can download from www.groove.net, install it and off you go. All of Groove's functionality and 80 per cent of the tools are included in the free version. You are limited to three workspaces per account, but you can create multiple accounts. When you put it to professional use and need its full power, it costs only around Rs 1,500 for the unlimited, standard version. If you're a student, you get a discount.

Groove understands how important you are—the IT managers and CEOs of tomorrow. Hence, the technology is made easy and affordable so everyone can use it and discover a better, safer way of living in a wired world. ■

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